

Not One Big Thing

HTML5 is now popularly used as an all-inclusive term. Typically it refers to a collection of new web specifications that enable next generation web applications. It can include anything from the true W3C HTML5 specification, CSS3, ECMAScript 5 and much more. When looked at together, they provide us as developers with new support for rich graphics and media, new JavaScript and DOM functionality to provide advanced programmability and standardise behaviour within the browsers.

HTML5 is a collection of scores of independent individual features. So it is wrong to consider it one giant entity. There is no one thing called “HTML5 support”. If you want to use HTML5 in your browser, you will have to check for support for individual features of HTML5, be it canvas, video, audio or geolocation.

Think of HTML as comprising tags and angle brackets. The interaction of these angle brackets with JavaScript, through the Document Object Model (DOM), is also defined in the HTML5 specification. The easiest way to sum up the components of HTML5 is as follows:

HTML5 = HTML5 + ECMAScript + CSS3 + SVG + GeoLocation + WebApps

As you can see, the HTML5 on the left refers to loose marketing and technology jargons. On the other hand, on the right side, it refers to the new markup, tags and features being introduced by the W3C working group.

ECMAScript is the formal body responsible for defining the language that is better known as JavaScript!

No need to start from scratch

One of the key benefits of using HTML5 is that it doesn't require you to relearn things you already know. If you're still stuck on HTML4, this is good news. If your web application worked yesterday in HTML 4, it will still work today in HTML5. Period. What HTML5 does is it gives you the tools and resources to improve your application.

Support

HTML5 is well supported by all major browsers – be it IE9, Firefox, Chrome or Safari. Even mobile browsers built into iPhone, certain Android devices and even Internet Explorer on Windows Phone Mango support HTML5. It doesn't matter which HTML5 feature you're using – designing better web forms, drawing on a canvas, playing a video or building web applications that work offline, you'll find that HTML5 is already well-supported.